

colours. Also, the phone is quite slow when working with images and loading games. However, the messaging system is quite quick.

Java application support brings a host of options to install and try out. Inbuilt games are addictive and should provide enough fun. Other interesting features include voice commands, an alarm clock, a calendar and PIM functionality.

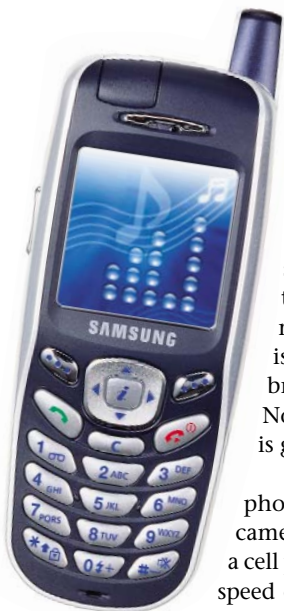
The Cubasis ringtone-mixing software offers some limited DJ-ing capabilities. The external snap-on camera does a good job at taking photos and comes with a flash. However, the pics you click don't look too good on the phone's screen.

We had no problems with voice clarity or signal reception, and the battery runs the better part of three and half days at normal usage.

Samsung SGH-X600

Price: Rs 12,999 **B**

The X600 closely follows its low-market model, the X100, with some minor changes. It comes with a superb integrated camera, infrared capabilities and an irritating external stub antenna. Priced at Rs 12,999, the X600 is a good buy, especially because of the good display and camera. The only thing that can go against it is the protruding antenna.



The blue-silver colour combination makes it to the X600, as with all Samsung phones. The dimensions are compact, and despite the presence of the external antenna, the phone fits comfortably in one's hand or pocket. This is one solidly put together, rugged phone.

Samsung has done the menu structure the smart way, bringing together the better aspects of other manufacturers' models. The interface is simple to understand and fast to browse. Messaging has also gone the Nokia way, and predictive texting is good.

The most interesting part of this phone is the rotating camera. This VGA camera is probably the best we've seen on a cell phone in terms of features offered and speed of operation. Zooming is superfast—but avoid zooming too much if you want a great-quality picture. To complement the camera, Samsung has put in a good 64K display. The screen is much brighter and more colourful than those seen on Nokia's and Siemens' phones in this category. The backlight is necessary for viewing the screen in direct sunlight.

There are plenty of options for customisation of sound. The polyphonic ringtones are sufficiently loud, and more melodious than other models. They don't sound as good as those on the E700, though.

The phone comes with nearly 9 MB of memory—enough for storing your pictures and Java applications. The only gripe we have is the lack of Bluetooth capability for transferring images.

The phone gives good voice clarity, and signal reception is above par. The battery lasts four days with normal use.

Samsung SGH-E700

Price: Rs 22,599 **C**

The SGH-E700 is arguably the best-looking clamshell phone to hit the market in recent times. The phone takes a complete new direction in the design implementation, and no cues from the older generation are visible here.

The E700 sports the most compact dimensions in its class. Though the phone is a clamshell, there are hardly any protruding edges—even the antenna is inbuilt. The upper flap has a small OLED display that shows the time and caller ID. Just above the display is the lens for the integrated camera.

Priced at Rs 22,599, the phone is quite expensive, considering the lack of tri-band support and Bluetooth.

The keypad is flat, black and reasonably large. A small chrome stud separates the keys, which are tactile, responsive and great for typing messages. The four way rocker works great, and also has pre-defined shortcuts.

The screen on the E700 is the best we've seen on any phone in this category, barring the Nokia 6600. The screen is bright enough to be used as a torch and colourful to the extent that you might imagine watching movies on it; it's sad you can't do that as yet.

The menu interface is the same, tried and tested one used on all other Samsung phones. Animated wallpapers and screensavers make good use of the colourful screen. The messaging system is fast and easy to use. The T9 text prediction is accurate.

The E700 comes with a fairly good integrated camera. There are a host of options such as multi-shot, night mode, self-shot etc. You can even change the exposure settings, which allows you to make the picture more bright.

The phone comes with around 9 MB of memory—large enough for storing lots of pictures and other applications. Bluetooth somehow doesn't make it to this phone; connectivity options include infrared and GPRS.

The E700 has decent signal reception and the voice clarity is good. The battery works for three days before dying, with normal usage.



LG G5400

Price: Rs 13,000 **B-**

The G5400 is a modest-looking, understated phone. It has all the essentials and the functionality is good. On the whole, however, at Rs 13,000 this phone is priced normally for the features it offers.

The design is elegant with nothing flashy about it. We reviewed the phone with an all-silver body; it looks monotonous—look out for the blue-silver combination, which looks much better. An LCD on the top cover works as the caller ID-cum-watch.

The keypad is one of the best-laid out keypads we've seen. There is ample space between the buttons, which are flat but highly responsive. The four-direction rocker and the soft-keys are a bit too closely placed.

The menu interface is similar on all LG phones, and we liked it. It is arranged vertically, and as you go down, icons pop up telling